MIL-C-16839D(OS)
29 May 1969
SUPERSEDING
MIL-C-16839C (Wep)
18 February 1960

MILITARY SPECIFICATION

CABLE, SPECIAL PURPOSE, ELECTRICAL (UNDERWATER USE)

This specification has been approved by the Naval Ordnance Systems Command, Department of the Navy.

1. SCOPE

1.1 Scope - This specification covers single and multi-conductor cable for underwater use.

1.2 Classification - Cable shall be of the following types, as specified (see 6.2).

Type DMU - Double conductor, demolition, magnetic
Type DNU - Double conductor, demolition, non-magnetic
Type DPU - Double conductor, oil resistant, portable
Type MSU - Multiple conductor, steel core
Type MTU - Multiple conductor, cotton or jute core
Type SPU - Single conductor, heat and oil resistant flexible

1.3 Cable size - The conductor size in thousands of circular mils (to the nearest thousand) or the number of conductors, is indicated by a numeral following the type designation letters for each cable (see 6.2).

2. APPLICABLE DOCUMENTS

* 2.1 The following documents of the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal, form a part of the specification to the extent specified herein.

SPECIFICATIONS

Federal

QQ-W-343	Wire, Electrical and Nonelectrical, Copper (Uninsulated)
QQ-W-461	Wire, Steel, Carbon (Round Bare and Coated)

FSC 6145

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SPECIFICATIONS

Federal (Continued)

QQ-W-470	Wire, Steel, Carbon, Spring, Music

Military

MIL-C-915	Cable, Cord and Wire, Electrical (Shipboard Use)
MIL-C-5424	Cable, Steel (Corrosion-Resisting), Flexible, Preformed (For Aeronautical Use)

STANDARDS

Federal

FED-STD-228	Cable and Wire, Insulated; Methods of Testing

(Copies of specifications, standards, drawings, and publications required by suppliers in connection with specific procurement functions should be obtained from the procuring activity or as directed by the contracting officer.)

3. REQUIREMENTS

3.1 Unless otherwise specified, all cables shall be manufactured in accordance with the applicable requirements of MIL-C-915.

3.2 Materials -

3.2.1 Conductors -

* 3.2.1.1 Copper - Copper conductors shall be in accordance with QQ-W-343, except that the inclusion of bismuth in the tin or tin-lead alloy coating is optional.

3.2.1.2 Conductors of other materials shall be as specified in 3.4.

3.2.2 Strength members - Members to increase the cable strength shall be as specified in 3.4.

3.2.3 Insulation, natural rubber -

3.2.3.1 Application - Each conductor shall be covered for its entire length with a well-centered wall of vulcanized rubber.

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3.2.3.2 General composition - The insulation compound shall consist of a homogeneous mixture with the rubber content being either fine Para or best quality plantation grown Hevea Brasiliensis rubber. The rubber shall not have been previously used in a compound. The compound shall contain only the following ingredients:

Rubber
Sulphur
Inorganic mineral fillers
Waxy hydrocarbons
Organic accelerators
Anti-oxidant

The sulphur shall be of the highest purity and of extreme fineness. The inorganic mineral fillers shall be of extreme fineness and shall be substantially free of moisture, red lead, free carbon, or any substance likely to exert a deleterious effect on the rubber. The waxy hydrocarbons shall be free from saponifiable matter.

3.2.3.3 Chemical analysis - Unless otherwise specifically approved, insulation removed from finished conductors shall conform to the following chemical requirements; percentages shown are by weight:

Rubber, not less than 40 percent
Waxy hydrocarbons, maximum 3 percent
Total sulphur, maximum, 3 percent
Free sulphur, maximum 0.5 percent
Inorganic mineral fillers, organic accelerators, and antioxidants, remainder
Specific gravity, between 0.93 and 1.14

3.2.3.4 Physical properties - Insulation removed from conductors not earlier than 48 hours after completion of the cable shall meet the following physical requirements at ordinary room temperature, 65° to 90° Fahrenheit (18° to 32° Centigrade).

3.2.3.4.1 The tensile strength shall be not less than 1800 pounds per square inch of original cross-sectional area.

3.2.3.4.2 The set shall be not more than 3/8 inch in 2 inches after testing in accordance with 4.3.1.1.

3.2.3.4.3 After testing in accordance with 4.3.1.1, the specimen shall undergo a second elongation from the "length after set" to at least 10 inches, prior to rupture.

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3.2.3.4.4 After 96 hours in an atmosphere of oxygen at 300 pounds per square inch pressure at a temperature of 158° F (70° C), the maximum depreciation of tensile strength and elongation shall not exceed 25 percent. A maximum variation of 10 pounds per square inch, 2° F (1° C) and one hour, in either direction during the aging process, is permissible.

* 3.2.4 Sheath -

3.2.4.1 Application - The sheath compound shall be applied concentrically about the grouped conductors and so cured as to assure their accurate centering within the finished sheath. The finished, sheathed cable shall be circular in cross section and of uniform diameter throughout its length.

3.2.4.1.1 The compound shall be cured in a close fitting mold or by the continuous extrusion method. After vulcanizing, the sheath shall be a firmly bound, strong, highly elastic, homogeneous mass. The sheath shall not be over-vulcanized.

* 3.2.4.2 Physical properties - Sheathing removed from finished cables not earlier than 48 hours after vulcanization, shall meet the following physical requirements at ordinary room temperature, 65 to 90° F (18 to 32° C).

* 3.2.4.2.1 The tensile strength shall be not less than 3500 pounds per square inch of original cross-sectional area.

* 3.2.4.2.2 The set shall be not more than 3/16 inch in 2 inches after testing in accordance with 4.3.1.1.

* 3.2.4.2.3 After testing in accordance with 4.3.1.1, the specimen shall undergo a record elongation from the "length after set" to at least 12 inches, prior to rupture.

* 3.2.4.2.4 After 96 hours in an atmosphere of oxygen at 300 pounds per square inch pressure and at a temperature of 158° F (70° C), the maximum depreciation of tensile strength and elongation shall not exceed 25 percent. A maximum variation of 10 pounds per square inch, 2° F (1° C) and one hour, in either direction during the aging process, is permissible.

* 3.2.4.3 Surface finish - The surface of the finished cable shall present a smooth, dense, shiny appearance free of all roughness or other irregularities. There shall be no objectionable waviness due to the failure of the sheath to tightly grip the conductors.

3.3 Manufacturer's identification -

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3.3.1 A marker tape in accordance with MIL-C-915 shall be provided for each cable except that the required information shall be:

Specification MIL-C-16839
Type and size designation. For type DMU and DNU, include whether magnetic or non-magnetic cable
Name of manufacturer
Name or location of plant
Year of manufacture

3.4 Detail requirements - Detail requirements or exceptions applicable to individual types are specified in Table I and in 3.4.1 through 3.4.6.2.

3.4.1 Type DMU -

3.4.1.1 Construction -

First - A strength member (and conductor) of steel wire in accordance with QQ-W-470, tin coated in accordance with QQ-W-461. Successive concentric lays to be of opposite hand.

Second - A conductor of coated wire in accordance with 3.2.1.1. Successive concentric lays to be of opposite hand on the steel strength member.

Third - A separator - Optional.

* Fourth - A wall of natural rubber insulation (see 3.2.3). The rubber shall be color-coded for the identification of conductors. The choice of colors is optional.

Fifth - A rayon inner braid (see MIL-C-915).

Sixth - Two conductors, twisted together with a lay not greater than 3 inches, and a treated moisture resistant jute filler free of excess wax (less than 2 percent extractable, the wax to be other than paraffin), to form an essentially round assembly.

Seventh - A binder braid over the assembly.

* Eighth - A natural rubber sheath:

General composition - The sheath compound shall consist of a homogeneous mixture with the rubber content being either fine Para or best quality plantation grown Hevea Brasiliensis rubber. The rubber shall not have been previously used in a compound. The remainder of the compound shall consist of sulphuric, inorganic mineral fillers, carbon black, anti-oxidants, and organic accelerators.

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TABLE I

PHYSICAL AND ELECTRICAL REQUIREMENTS

REQUIREMENT	UNIT OF MEASUREMENT	TYPE OF CABLE					
		DMU-4	DNU-4	DPU-10	MSU-21	MTU-7	SPU-500
Operating voltage	volts, a.c., max. volts, d.c., max.	300 500	300 500	600 1000	600 1000	600 1000	600 1000
Conductor size	strands	7 steel and 12 copper	19	19	7	41	1225 (7 x 7 x 25)
	diameter, inches	0.0142	0.0142	0.0234	0.0242	0.0063	0.0201
Insulation thickness	inches, min.	0.0156	0.0156	0.047	0.06	0.031	0.11
Sheath thickness	inches, min.	0.04	0.04	0.06		0.125	0.12
Inner sheath thickness	inches, approx.				0.13		
Total sheath thickness	inches, min.				0.26		
Outside diameter	inches	0.34 ±.01	0.34 ±.01	0.595 ±.015	1.73 ±.03	0.66 ±.015	1.485 ±.035
Conductor resistance	ohms/1000 feet at 68° F (20° C), max.	4.3	4.3	1.05	2.73	7.15	0.0225
Insulation resistance	megohms/1000 feet, min.	100	100	500	500	300	100
Dielectric strength	volts, min.	1500	1500	2500	2500	2500	2500
Abrasion resistance	number of revolutions of wheel without wearing through sheath	50	50				
Air leakage	cubic inches			0	0	0	0
Water leakage	cubic inches			0	0	0	0

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Chemical analysis - Sheathing removed from finished cables shall conform to the following chemical requirements; percentages shown are by weight:

Rubber, minimum, 60 percent
Waxy hydrocarbons, maximum, 3.3 percent
Total sulphur, maximum, 3 percent
Free sulphur, maximum, 1.2 percent
Carbon black, minimum, 20 percent
Inorganic mineral filler, anti-oxidants and organic accelerators, remainder
Specific gravity, minimum, 1.12

3.4.1.2 Marking - The sheath shall be marked "Type DMU* - MAGNETIC DEMOLITION CABLE." This marking, to be repeated at least once per foot, shall be resonably permanent under all normal rough handling and storage conditions and shall be printed in contrasting color on the sheath along the entire length of the cable. The above sheath marking is in addition to the marking tape called for in 3.3.1.

* Applicable size number (see 1.3)

3.4.2 Type DNU -

3.4.2.1 Construction -

First - A conductor of tin or tin-lead alloy coated cadmium bronze wire of 85 percent conductivity grade; 80,000 pounds per square inch minimum tensile strength. Successive concentric lays to be of opposite hand.

Second - A separator (see MIL-C-915).

* Third - A wall of natural rubber insulation. (See 3.2.3.) The rubber shall be color-coded for the identification of conductors. The choice of colors is optional.

Fourth - A rayon inner braid. (See MIL-C-915.)

Fifth - Two conductors, twisted together with a length of lay not greater than 3 inches, and a treated moisture resistant jute filler free of excess wax (less than 2 percent extractable, the wax to be other than paraffin), to form an essentially round assembly.

Sixth - A binder braid over the assembly.

* Seventh - A natural rubber sheath.

General composition - The sheath compound shall consist of a homogeneous mixture with the rubber content being either fine Para or best quality plantation grown

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Hevea Brasiliensis rubber. The rubber shall not have been previously used in a compound. The remainder of the compound shall consist of sulphuric, inorganic mineral fillers, carbon black, anti-oxidants, and organic accelerators.

Chemical analysis - Sheathing removed from finished cables shall conform to the following chemical requirements; percentages shown are by weight:

Rubber, minimum, 60 percent
Waxy hydrocarbons, maximum, 3.3 percent
Total sulphur, maximum, 3 percent
Free sulphur, maximum, 1.2 percent
Carbon black, minimum, 20 percent
Inorganic mineral filler, anti-oxidants and organic accelerators, remainder
Specific gravity, minimum, 1.12

3.4.2.2 Marking - The sheath shall be marked "Type DNU* - NON-MAGNETIC DEMOLITION CABLE." This marking, to be repeated at least once per foot, shall be reasonably permanent under all normal rough handling and storage conditions and shall be printed in contrasting color on the sheath along the entire length of the cable. The above sheath marking is in addition to the marking tape called for in 3.3.1.

* Applicable size number. (See 1.3.)

* 3.4.3 Type DPU -

3.4.3.1 Construction -

First - A conductor of coated copper wire in accordance with 3.2.1.1. Successive concentric lays to be of opposite hand.

Second - A separator. (See MIL-C-915.)

* Third - A wall of Butyl rubber. (See MIL-C-915.) The rubber shall be color-coded for the identification of conductors. The choice of colors is optional.

Fourth - Two conductors, twisted together with a length of lay not greater than 5 inches, and synthetic rubber fillers to form an essentially round assembly.

Fifth - A binder braid over the assembly.

Sixth - A polychloroprene sheath. (See MIL-C-915.)

3.4.4 Type MSU -

3.4.4.1 Construction -

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Strength member -

First - A 1/4 inch diameter (7 x 19) steel cable in accordance with MIL-C-5424, except that there shall be no lubricating compound applied to the cable. Also acceptable, a 1/4 inch diameter (7 x 7) steel cable, minimum breaking strength 6100 pounds, which is in accordance with MIL-C-5424 and the above exception in all other respects.

Second - Two layers of cotton braid. (See MIL-C-915.)

Conductor -

Third - A conductor of coated copper wire in accordance with 3.2.1.1 concentric lay.

* Fourth - A wall of Butyl rubber. (See MIL-C-915.) The rubber shall be color-coded for the identification of conductors. The choice of colors is optional.

Fifth - An inner braid. Required only if necessary for circuit identification. (See MIL-C-915.)

Sixth - Twenty-one conductors, twisted around the steel strength member in successive concentric lays of suitable length and opposite hand, and fillers to form an essentially round assembly.

Seventh - A binder braid over the assembly.

Eighth - A polychloroprene inner sheath. (See MIL-C-915.)

Ninth - A cotton reinforcement. (See MIL-C-915.)

Tenth - A polychloroprene outer sheath. (See MIL-C-915.)

3.4.5 Type MTU -

3.4.5.1 Construction -

First - A conductor of coated copper wire in accordance with 3.2.1.1 Bunch stranded.

Second - A separator. (See MIL-C-915.)

* Third - A wall of Butyl rubber. (See MIL-C-915.) The rubber shall be color-coded for the identification of conductors. The choice of colors is optional.

Fourth - An inner braid. Required only if necessary for circuit identification. (See MIL-C-915.)

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Fifth - Seven conductors, twisted in a concentric lay around a central core of impregnated cotton or jute, and fillers to form an essentially round assembly. (See MIL-C-915.) The length of lay shall be not greater than 3 inches. A conductor shall not be used in or for the central core.

Sixth - A binder braid over the assembly.

Seventh - A polychloroprene sheath. (See MIL-C-915.)

* 3.4.6 Type SPU -

3.4.6.1 Construction -

First - A conductor of uncoated copper wire in accordance with 3.2.1.1. Rope-lay-stranding with concentric-lay or bunch-lay stranded members, as applicable.

Second - A separator. (See MIL-C-915.)

Third - A wall of Butyl rubber. (See MIL-C-915.)

Fourth - A cotton reinforcement. (See MIL-C-915.)

Fifth - A polychloroprene sheath. (See MIL-C-915.)

3.4.6.2 Cold bend resistance of sheath - The sheath shall not crack at -22° F (-30° C) when the cable is bent two turns around a three-inch mandrel.

3.5 Workmanship - The material as specified herein shall be processed as required in accordance with the best practice for a high quality cable and shall be suitable for its intended purpose.

4. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS

4.1 Responsibility for inspection - Unless otherwise specified in the contract or purchase order, the supplier is responsible for the performance of all inspection requirements as specified herein. Except as otherwise specified in the contract or order, the supplier may use his own or any other facilities suitable for the performance of the inspection requirements specified herein, unless disapproved by the Government. The Government reserves the right to perform any of the inspections set forth in the specification where such inspections are deemed necessary to assure supplies and services conform to prescribed requirements.

4.1.1 Unless otherwise specified in the following paragraphs, all sampling and testing shall be in accordance with MIL-C-915, as applicable.

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4.2 Unless otherwise specified in the contract or order, lot quality conformance tests only will be required.

4.2.1 Quality conformance tests required - Tests required for each cable type shall be as specified in Tables II and III, applicable documents, and as stated below.

4.2.2 Sample size - The sample to be subjected to the physical tests shall consist of three specimens of sufficient length selected at random from each lot of completed cable.

4.2.3 Action in case of failure -

4.2.3.1 Inspection of product and electrical tests - Each continuous length of cable failing any of these tests shall be rejected.

* 4.2.3.2 Physical tests - Failure of any specimen in any of these tests shall cause rejection of the represented lot. Lots found unacceptable shall be resubmitted for Government inspection only after all units are re-examined and retested and all defective units are removed or defects corrected. Resubmitted lots shall be kept separate from new lots.

4.3 Insulation and sheath test - Testing for physical and chemical properties of insulation and sheath materials shall be in accordance with MIL-C-915, except as follows.

* 4.3.1 Natural rubber - (See 3.2.3, 3.4.1.1 Construction, Eighth, and 3.4.2.1 Construction, Seventh.)

* 4.3.1.1 Set test - A test specimen, having a length of not less than 6 inches, marked with bench marks 2 inches apart shall be placed in the jaws of a testing machine and stretched until the bench marks are six (6) inches apart for both the 40 and 60 percent rubber compounds (see 3.2.3, 3.4.1.1 Construction, Eighth, and 3.4.2.1 Construction, Seventh). After the termination of stretch, the test specimen shall be released within 5 seconds and the set determined 1 minute after the beginning of release.

* 4.4 Abrasion resistance test - The specimen shall be a 2-foot length of completed cable.

* 4.4.1 Procedure - The specimen shall be hung with a 90-degree arc of contact over a 7-inch diameter abrasion wheel made up of twelve 3/8-inch diameter fine grade tungsten carbide rods and two 7-inch diameter phenolic discs arranged in the form of a squirrel cage. A 15-pound weight shall be attached to the free end of the specimen. The tests shall be made at room temperature with the abrasion wheel rotating at 60 revolutions per minute (r.p.m.) in the direction which tends to lift the 15-pound weight. The number of wheel revolutions required to wear through a measured thickness of the sheath wall shall be determined and recorded.

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TABLE II

QUALITY CONFORMANCE TESTS REQUIRED ON SAMPLE LENGTHS

TEST TITLE	SOURCE OF TEST	TYPE OF CABLE					
		DMU-4	DNU-4	DPU-10	MSU-21	MTU-7	SPU-500
Copper strand area, tensile strength and coating	QQ-W-343	X					
Steel strand area, tensile strength and coating	QQ-W-461 QQ-W-470	X					
Strand area, tensile strength and coating	QQ-W-343		X 1/		X		
Strand area and tensile strength	QQ-W-343			X		X	X
Insulation and sheath properties 2/	4.3	X	X				
Insulation and sheath properties 2/	MIL-C-915			X	X	X	X
Hot oil test	MIL-C-915			X			X
Water and air leakage	4.5			X	X	X	X
Flammability	MIL-C-915						X
Cold bend	MIL-C-915						X

1/ See "Construction, First" of 3.4.2, Type DNU.

2/ Chemical analysis to be performed on initial lot only or when specifically requested by the Government inspector.

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TABLE III

QUALITY CONFORMANCE TESTS REQUIRED ON EACH CONTINUOUS LENGTH

TEST TITLE	SOURCE OF TEST	TYPE OF CABLE					
		DMU-4	DNU-4	DPU-10	MSU-21	MTU-7	SPU-500
Inspection of product	MIL-C-915	X	X	X	X	X	X
Conductor resistance	FED-STD-228, Method 6021	X	X	X	X	X	X
Insulation resistance	MIL-C-915	X	X	X	X	X	X
Dielectric strength	MIL-C-915	X	X	X	X	X	X
Abrasion resistance	4.4	X	X				

* 4.5 Water and air leakage - The specimen shall be a 30-inch section of completed cable with or without end seal.

* 4.5.1 Apparatus - The apparatus shall consist of a testing tank, of 15-inch length and suitable diameter to accommodate the test specimen, fitted with Navy Standard watertight stuffing tubes with approved packing, connected to the pressure system, a pressure control and leakage detection device permitting test by either air or water under pressure, and necessary connections, gages and valves between testing tank and pressure control system.

* 4.5.2 Procedure - The specimen shall be sealed in place into or through the testing tank. Air pressure shall be applied to detect leakage through the cable sheath or end seal, and to enable location and correction of leaks through stuffing tubes and packing. The cable sheath or end seal and the gland shall not leak under this air pressure. After the assembly has withstood the air pressure for a period of 30 minutes without leakage, the specimen shall be subjected to water pressure at room temperature for a period of 4 hours. The amount of water leakage, if any, shall be determined to a precision of 1 cubic inch.

* 4.5.3 Pressures - The air and water pressures applied shall be 75 p.s.i.

5. PREPARATION FOR DELIVERY

5.1 Packaging, packing and marking - The cable length specified in 5.2 shall be packaged, packed and marked in accordance with the requirements of MIL-C-915, as applicable.

5.2 Cable length - All cable shall be furnished on reels in standard lengths as follows:

5.2.1 Types DMU and DNU - 1000 ±50 feet.

5.2.2 Type DPU - 2000 ±200 feet, except that a maximum of 30 percent of the total order may be in shorter lengths, as follows:

(a) 900 to 1800 feet - not more than 30 percent of the total order.

(b) 450 to 900 feet - not more than 10 percent of the total order.

(c) 200 to 450 feet - not more than 5 percent of the total order.

5.2.3 Type MSU - 1000 ±50 feet, except that a maximum of 10 percent of the total order may be 500 to 950 foot lengths.

5.2.4 Type MTU - 1000 ±50 feet.

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5.2.5 Type SPU - 500 ±50 feet, except that a maximum of 10 percent of the total order may be in random or remnant lengths as listed in Section 6 of MIL-C-915.

6. NOTES

6.1 Intended use - All cable covered by this specification is suitable for underwater use. Primary uses are as follows:

6.1.1 Type DMU - For firing explosives. High tensile strength. Magnetic characteristics. Not for permanent installation.

6.1.2 Type DNU - For firing explosives. Medium tensile strength. Non-magnetic characteristics. Not for permanent installation.

6.1.3 Types DPU and MSU - For degaussing range installations.

6.1.4 Type MTU - For degaussing magnetometer installations.

6.1.5 Type SPU - For deperming use.

* 6.2 Ordering data - Procurement documents should specify the following:

(a) Title, number, and date of this specification.

(b) Type and size of cable required (see 1.2 and 1.3).

(c) Quantity.

* 6.3 Changes from previous issue - The margins of this specification are marked with an asterisk to indicate where changes (additions, modifications, corrections, deletions) from the previous issue were made. This was done as a convenience only and the Government assumes no liability whatsoever for any inaccuracies in these notations. Bidders and contractors are cautioned to evaluate the requirements of this document based on the entire content irrespective of the marginal notations and relationship to the last previous issue.

Project No. 6145-N005

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SPECIFICATION ANALYSIS SHEET

Form Approved
Budget Bureau No. 119-R004

INSTRUCTIONS

This sheet is to be filled out by personnel either Government or contractor, involved in the use of the specification in procurement of products for ultimate use by the Department of Defense. This sheet is provided for obtaining information on the use of this specification which will insure that suitable products can be procured with a minimum amount of delay and at the least cost. Comments and the return of this form will be appreciated. Fold on lines on reverse side, staple in corner, and send to preparing activity *(as indicated on reverse hereof)*.

SPECIFICATION
MIL-C-16839D(OS) CABLE, SPECIAL PURPOSE, ELECTRICAL (UNDERWATER USE)

ORGANIZATION *(Of submitter)*	CITY AND STATE

CONTRACT NO.	QUANTITY OF ITEMS PROCURED	DOLLAR AMOUNT
		$

MATERIAL PROCURED UNDER A

☐ DIRECT GOVERNMENT CONTRACT ☐ SUBCONTRACT

1. HAS ANY PART OF THE SPECIFICATION CREATED PROBLEMS OR REQUIRED INTERPRETATION IN PROCUREMENT USE?

A. GIVE PARAGRAPH NUMBER AND WORDING.

B. RECOMMENDATIONS FOR CORRECTING THE DEFICIENCIES.

2. COMMENTS ON ANY SPECIFICATION REQUIREMENT CONSIDERED TOO RIGID

3. IS THE SPECIFICATION RESTRICTIVE?

☐ YES ☐ NO IF "YES", IN WHAT WAY?

4. REMARKS *(Attach any pertinent data which may be of use in improving this specification. If there are additional papers, attach to form and place both in an envelope addressed to preparing activity)*

SUBMITTED BY *(Printed or typed name and activity)*	DATE

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